

*We acknowledge the use of OpenAI's ChatGPT as a supportive tool in drafting and refining portions of the text.

Environmental Futures and Public Communication (ENVR 245)

1. COURSE INFORMATION

Course Title	Course Code Number	Credit Value
Environmental Futures and Public Communication	ENVR 245	3 Credits

Schedule: Tuesdays and Thursdays from 1:00 to 2:30pm, Forest Sciences Centre (FSC) 1215

2. COURSE DESCRIPTION

This course explores environmental communication, sustainability transitions, and public engagement strategies related to environmental change. Students will examine how environmental information is shared through media, policy, scientific reporting, and public campaigns. Topics include climate communication, urban sustainability, ecological resilience, misinformation, environmental storytelling, and community engagement strategies.

3. LEARNING OUTCOMES

1. Explain key environmental sustainability concepts and their societal implications.
2. Analyze environmental communication approaches across different media formats.
3. Evaluate environmental case studies using critical and evidence-based reasoning.
4. Design communication products tailored to different public audiences.
5. Reflect on environmental issues and engagement strategies in local and global contexts.

4. COURSE STRUCTURE & LEARNING MATERIALS

ENVR 245 emphasizes discussion, participation, collaborative activities, and applied communication exercises as a way of strengthening students' understanding of environmental sustainability topics. In addition to lectures delivered by the instructor, the course will include workshops, case studies, interactive exercises, and guest speakers working in sustainability, media, environmental planning, and public outreach sectors.

Canvas site: Class materials (e.g. lecture slides, assignment instructions, weekly summaries, announcements, and supplementary readings) will be posted on Canvas throughout the term. Every Friday, a weekly overview will be posted outlining the upcoming topics, required readings, and important reminders for assignments and activities.

Course textbook and readings: It is expected that students will come to class having reviewed the required materials and prepared to engage in discussions and activities. The course textbook is: Morrison, L. & Patel, R. (2021). *Communicating Environmental Futures: Media, Sustainability and Public Action*. Pacific Northwest Academic Press. Students may purchase the textbook through the UBC bookstore or access selected chapters electronically through the university library system. Additional readings, articles, podcasts, reports, and multimedia resources will be posted throughout the term in Canvas modules.

Participation tools: Some class participation activities may use online polling and collaborative discussion platforms. Students are expected to participate actively in workshops, peer review sessions, small group discussions, and in-class activities.

Software tools: Selected assignments may involve the use of presentation, infographic, mapping, or visualization

software. Tutorials and support resources will be provided in advance.

5. SCHEDULE OF TOPICS

This schedule is provisional and may be adjusted depending on class progress and guest speaker availability.

Week	Dates	Topic	Readings & deadlines
Unit I. Environmental Foundations and Public Understanding			
1	Sept. 3	Course introduction and syllabus overview	None
	Sept. 5	Understanding sustainability and environmental systems	Reading: Sustainability in Practice
2	Sept. 10	Public perceptions of environmental change	Article: Environmental Risk Perception
	Sept. 12	Guest lecture & discussion: Environmental journalism	None
3	Sept. 17	Media narratives and environmental storytelling	Podcast response activity
	Sept. 19	Workshop: Communicating scientific uncertainty	Assignment 1 Due
Unit II. Communication, Technology & Engagement			
4	Sept. 24	Social media and environmental campaigns	Reading: Digital Environmental Advocacy
	Sept. 26	Visual communication and infographic design	None
5	Oct. 1	Climate misinformation and public trust	Case study review
	Oct. 3	Workshop: Designing communication materials	Assignment 2.1 Due
6	Oct. 8	Community engagement and participatory outreach	None
	Oct. 10	Guest lecture: Environmental policy communication	Quiz Unit 1
Unit III. Future Environmental Challenges			
7	Oct. 15	Urban resilience and future planning	Reading: Resilient Cities Framework
	Oct. 17	Workshop: Scenario planning activities	Assignment 2.2 Due
8	Oct. 22	Environmental ethics and emerging technologies	None
	Oct. 24	Course wrap-up and future directions	Final project proposal due

6. ASSESSMENTS OF LEARNING

Item	Mark	Due Date
Class participation	10%	Throughout the term
Short quizzes	20%	Various dates
Assignment 1: Reflection blog post	15%	Sunday Sep. 22
Assignment 2: Environmental infographic	25%	Friday Oct. 25
Assignment 3: Communication strategy project	20%	Friday Nov. 29
Final reflection portfolio	10%	Sunday Dec. 8

7. COURSE POLICIES

Late assignments: Late submissions will receive a deduction of 5% per day unless prior arrangements have been made with the instructor.

Academic integrity: Students are expected to follow university academic integrity policies and properly cite all external sources used in assignments and projects.

Use of AI tools: AI tools may be used in selected assignments where explicitly permitted by the instructor. Students remain responsible for the originality and accuracy of submitted work.

8. STUDENT WELLBEING & SUPPORT

Student wellbeing is important to the instructional team. Students are encouraged to seek support when needed and make use of campus wellbeing, accessibility, and academic support services available through UBC student resources.